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CUET, A Test of Learning, Not Memory



Since I took charge of the University Grants Commission (UGC) in February, people in general, including friends from media, have often asked me about my vision for the higher education regulator. The questions multiplied since the UGC announced in May the plan to conduct the first-ever Common University Entrance Test (CUET) for admissions into central university courses and other willingly participating universities. So far, 89 universities, including the central universities, have agreed to admit students through CUET this year. I'm sure the number will increase exponentially in the coming years.

There is consensus, including among critics, that the CUET is a much-needed step towards making our higher education more accessible and equitable. Recently, a young lady, after finishing an interview with me on CUET, told me she could never imagine studying in the top-ranking colleges as she had scored only 70 per cent in her board examinations. She felt her fate was sealed once board results were out. What she has missed out will not happen to future generations. With the introduction of CUET, the days of skyrocketing board marks required for university admissions are a thing of the past. CUET has brought fresh hope to all aspirants, provided a level playing field and has been welcomed very positively by all stakeholders in the country.

India has multiple education boards. Each board differs in how marks are awarded. Every year, it seems the boards are vying with each other to inflate marks. In some boards, students get very high marks, while in state boards, it is impossible to get high marks for the same effort. And these students will never have an opportunity to get admission in universities like Delhi University.

Even in universities that have entrance exams, they are written with pen and paper, requiring teachers to correct lakhs of scripts manually. Admissions based either on board exams or handwritten essay-type entrance tests have their own problems. In both cases, it is humans who correct the essay-type long answers. After a teacher corrects a few dozen answer scripts, fatigue sets in. Therefore, it is possible there will be variations in marking. In many university admissions, even a difference of one mark induced by human inaccuracy can make a difference.

An advantage I see with CUET is that it is a computer-